opened and the CFI crawled out, signalling to me to turn around and go back for a solo flight. I looked at Babs Sir, who gave me a thumbs up. I blinked away tears of joy and went for the first solo flight of my career. Even though the start was bumpy, I had cleared my solo check, becoming the first in my course to go solo. When I approached for landing, I saw Babs Sir standing against the ACP hut* at the start of the runway. He was smiling. I was smiling too. I taxied my aircraft back to the hangar and ran straight to Babs Sir to tell him everything in detail.

'Your sortie is not over until you sign,' Babs Sir reminded me, so I turned back and ran towards the hangar. In all the excitement, I had forgotten to sign off on Form 700. Before I could go back to Babs Sir, the CFI called me to his office for a debriefing. After this I ran straight to Babs Sir and told him everything that had happened in a single breath. Anuradha and Supreet listened intently.

'I knew you would do it. You've made me proud,' Babs Sir said.

Anuradha and Supreet congratulated me. The next thing I did was call my parents from the STD phone in our squadron's cafeteria. They couldn't believe what I told them.

'Did you fly alone?' Papaji asked.

'Did you take the aircraft into the sky all by yourself?' Maa asked excitedly.

'How many birds did you hit?' Dada joked. My family was very happy and proud. And I was happy that they were happy. That was what I had always wanted to do.

The first term's flying training was over for me before any other cadet had cleared it. Another good thing was that I had been granted liberty during the weekends to go out into the city—part of the privilege I had earned after clearing my solo. But I preferred to spend it at Anuradha's house, savouring home-cooked food and talking endlessly with her and her mother. The bad side of clearing the solo first, however, was that I had been assigned to Wing Commander Patil as his pupil. It meant that I could no longer fly with Babs Sir. But it was all for my good, Babs Sir had convinced